Despite the peril in approaching the border from the East, as reflected in official messages related to border policy, many residents from both sides routinely faced interruptions and reminders of the city's other half, whether by billboard-style signage, radio and television signals, or other means of transcending the physical border. In actuality East and West Berlin together formed a whole city under the state of tense separation. As Emily Pugh contends, "East and West Germany relied on one another to define themselves, even when official rhetoric attempted to deny or ignore the other's existence and legitimacy."[17] The peace accomplished by stalemate involved shared acknowledgment and increasing bifurcation.

The circulation of mostly western-based narratives advanced ideas of the East being a connected, though often abject, part of the whole city. For a growing industry of American-authored Cold War cultural productions, a sense of West Berlin's Americanized enclaves and resurgent cultural city life highlighted that half of the city as an oasis of freedom with a massive wall as its defining endpoint. In contrast, East Berlin was cast as the foreign and forbidden urban other, epitomized by its stark wall. East Berlin existed as a space of interwoven fact and projection in American cultural accounts. The 1962 NBC production of *The Tunnel*, for example, featured actual footage of West Berlin students successfully building an underground passageway to smuggle people across the border, subsidized, in part, by funds from NBC.[18] Other fictionalized accounts imagine escaping East Berlin to achieve justice or freedom, resonant far away from divided Germany. In one example, the film *Lilies of the Field* (1963), starring Sidney Poitier as former GI Homer Smith, Poitier's character struggles to find steady work as a builder in the American Southwest when he comes across a group of East German nuns living in isolation, their escape over the Wall central to their bonding with Smith against a backdrop of a discriminatory U.S. culture. (Poitier won an Oscar for his performance, the first awarded to a black actor in a starring role.)[19] Such cultural productions frame East Berlin as a place to escape lest one be stuck "behind" the Berlin Wall.[20] Such accounts spatialize East Berlin as a place of isolation and the German Democratic Republic as a universal site of deprivation and distrust.

What was life more fully like in East Berlin? There are numerous accounts by those who lived in East Germany of the routine struggles and repressive tactics of life in East Berlin, and in the German Democratic Republic more broadly. Programs of border control, state surveillance, and